

Trickle power for consumers

Trickle power can be used for consumer electronics if the trend for reducing the power footprint of devices continues

Trickle power, however, has a range of applications when it comes to applications on a larger scale, especially in the industrial sector. "We are focused on power over distance for industrial applications such as wireless sensors for trickle charging batteries or battery-free sensors. Wireless sensors enabled by Powercast technology will provide greater life and reduced maintenance (from not having to change batteries) to wireless sensors for a range of applications including energy management, building automation, location tracking, and defence." This has many implications for a number of sectors. Any kind of monitoring on a system, through small cameras, infra red sensors, or other kinds of sensors, can be done through a Powercast setup. All the walkie-talkies in an area can be remotely powered using a trickle charge. Smart RFID tags, similar to the tags embedded in consumer goods, can be used to track, say all the animals in a national park, and monitor their health at the same time.

Powercast's system is built in such a way that any number of Powercasters can transmit power to any number of power receivers, configured within the same grid. This allows for great flexibility at the point of deployment, and scales well when more units have to be added to any given configuration. "Powercast has many innovations related to sending and receiving power over distance. Our RF Powerharvester components work over a wide operating range which makes them useful for many applications as opposed to a design that only works in a narrow operating range of input power and device load," according to Harry Ostaffe Director, Marketing and Business Development, Power-

cast. Powercast has teamed up with at least 200 companies for developing and implementing the trickle power technology, and also sells kits that can be used to develop applications.

A wireless world

Apart from the convenience aspect of the technology, there are many other advantages as well. The environment stands to benefit tremendously if this is implemented on a large scale. The large number of adapters and wires will be done away with, as well as devices such as multi-plug points. The packaging material used to deliver these wires along with the device can also be done away with. Batteries, that are terribly harmful to the environment can be replaced by discreet wireless power sources. The cost of materials used to make these wires and batteries and running the factories that do all of this can also be done away with. This kind of technology can greatly reduce the hazards of working with devices that use wires and plugs in explosive environments, in hospitals and in combat situations. When it comes to industrial applications, wireless power to sensor networks, or tagged networks not only simplifies implementation, but also allows for the components of a network to do more. For example, trickle charged smartcards or RFID tags can be configured to collect and relay information, as they can be wirelessly powered. Deploying networked nodes in the atmosphere for collecting weather information, underwater, or even in outer space becomes more efficient as each module can be powered up at a distance. Widespread use of wireless power technologies, is however, still some time away. 

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